and village, and even within the warmth of our families. This division has cleaved our society into fragments of animosity, discontent and fear.

Everywhere in India, the atmosphere simmers like a trigger bomb, awaiting a fanatical instigator to ignite the fuse, leading to riots, mass violence and fratricide. Each indoctrinated radicalized member of our society and family plays a scripted role in a potential genocide or a civil war. They seldom realize they are just pawns in a design to destroy the plural Indian fabric. Indeed, the seeds of a mental and virtual civil war have already been sown. A glance at the annals of history reveals the devastating consequences of politics driven by hatred and fascist tendencies, a perilous path that India now treads.

Amid it all, a pervasive sense of unyielding authoritarianism emanated from the country's leadership, with the Prime Minister and his party displaying a chilling indifference. Our collective plight just didn't seem to reach their ivory towers, and the manufactured narrative that they engineered was completely removed from our lived reality. India was effectively orphaned, for our government was no longer of, by or for the people.

This hopelessness has been magnified tenfold by a common lament that has echoed through the hearts and minds of concerned citizens for the past few years. Where is the Opposition, we ask? Where are the stalwart leaders of the yesteryears who would have dared to challenge this thick smoke choking India? Where are the democrats, socialists, liberals, Gandhians, leftists and Lohiaites, all of whom shaped this nation, through India's freedom struggle and later? And even more personally, there are inescapable questions: Where do we stand? What contributions can we make? Whom should we look to in these trying times?

A Ray of Hope

Then, like a ray of light in the darkness, came the announcement of the Bharat Jodo Yatra—an epic odyssey spanning approximately 4,000